2. To keep expenditure within the family food budget.
3. To take into account the food preference of individual members.
4. Using methods of cooking to retain maximum nutrients.
5. To economize on time, fuel and energy.
6. To serve attractive and appetizing meals.

Providing a meal that would be enjoyed and accepted by one and all in the family is rather difficult. Individual preferences, varied nutrient needs, varied food habits, are a few factors that would influence meal planning. The crucial aspect to be considered then is how best to plan adequate and satisfying meals, within the socio-cultural, economic, regional and psychological framework of the individual.

The various factors influencing meal planning are illustrated in figure 1.4

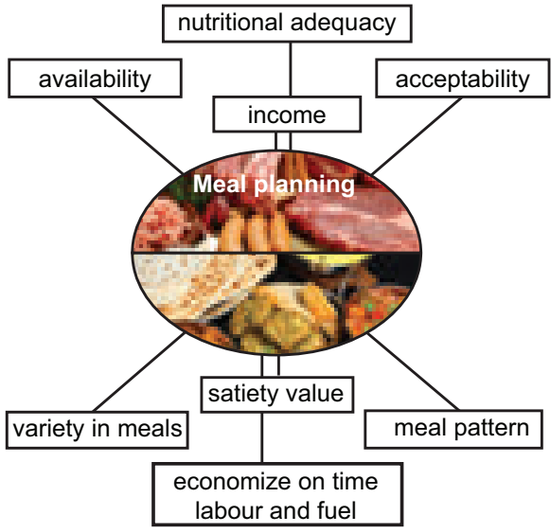


Fig. 1.4 Factors affecting Meal Planning

1.3.2 Factors affecting Meal Planning

1. Nutritional adequacy:

The nutritional requirement of the individual to be served is an important consideration in meal planning. This point is particularly important when we are planning meals for a family. In a family, there might be different individuals - a child, an adolescent, an adult, a pregnant woman or an elderly person. Each of these individuals has his/her own specific nutrient requirements. **The basic aim while planning meals should be to fulfill the nutrient needs of each individual**

How do we ensure this? This can be ensured by planning balanced meals according to the recommended dietary intakes for different individuals. No single food can meet all the nutritional requirements. Therefore, to achieve a balance of nutrients a combination of different foods need to be included in the diet. The diet can be planned by including foods from the four food groups. Although all nutrients are important, the requirement for certain nutrients is proportionately higher in certain age groups. e.g.- Iron in an adolescent girl and a pregnant woman. Therefore identifying rich sourcesof various nutrients within the same food group is required. e.g.- wholecereals and rice flakes are rich in iron among cereals, milk and fish have high calcium content among animal foods.

2. Food cost and economy

The expenditure on food is an important part of a family's budget and it is influenced by

- ❖ Family size
- ❖ The number of children
- ❖ Age group
- ❖ Activity and
- ❖ Special needs of pregnancy, lactation and disease condition.

The proportionate expenditure on food depends upon the income levels i.e. it increases with a decrease in total income. Moreover, in case of low-income level, a higher proportion is spent on buying staples rather than protective foods like milk, vegetables,and fruits. Therefore the aim should be to achieve

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